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US HITS IRAN 'VERY HARD'; HORMUZ CLAIMS CLASH

UAE strongly condemns fresh Iranian attacks on Gulf countries

DUBAI

BY STEPHEN N. R.
Senior Associate Editor

US President Donald Trump said yesterday that the United States had hit Iran "very hard" after Tehran attacked a commercial vessel in the Strait of Hormuz, as the latest military exchanges spread across the Gulf, prompted fresh Iranian attacks on neighbouring states and drew strong condemnation from the UAE.

The escalation began after an Iranian strike on a Cyprus-flagged container ship in the strategic waterway left the vessel ablaze and one Indian crew member missing. Washington responded with strikes on about 140 Iranian military targets, saying they were aimed at degrading Tehran's ability to threaten commercial shipping.

Gulf states attacked

Iran retaliated by launching missiles and drones towards Bahrain, Kuwait, Qatar, Jordan and Oman. Qatar said three people were injured by falling debris after its air defences intercepted incoming missiles, while Iran's Revolutionary Guards claimed



WAM

President His Highness Sheikh Mohamed Bin Zayed Al Nahyan is received by Abdul Fattah Al Sissi, President of Egypt, at El Alamein International Airport. The leaders discussed the latest developments in the Middle East and ongoing efforts to address them and reaffirmed their commitment to continued consultation on various issues in light of the shared challenges the region is facing, necessitating closer cooperation to safeguard regional security and stability.

they had also struck targets in Oman, a country that has rarely been targeted during the conflict.

Tehran also declared the Strait of Hormuz closed until further notice. However, the

United States insisted the strategic waterway remained open, highlighting sharply conflicting claims over one of the world's most important energy and shipping routes.

"We hit them very hard last night," Trump told CNN. He said Washington and Tehran had been close to reaching an agreement before Iran attacked the merchant vessel.

"They were giving up everything, and then all of a sudden two hours after that they hit a ship with a drone. These people, there is something wrong with them," Trump said.

Blatant violation

The UAE strongly condemned Iran's renewed missile and drone attacks on Bahrain, Kuwait, Qatar, Jordan and Oman, describing them as a blatant violation of the sovereignty of those countries and a serious threat to regional security and stability. In a statement, the Ministry of Foreign Affairs reaffirmed the UAE's full solidarity with the affected countries and reiterated its support for all measures aimed at safeguarding their security and stability.

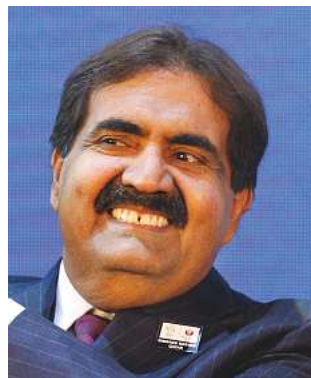
Meanwhile, the UAE's National Emergency Crisis and Disasters Management Authority (NCEMA) said the situation remained stable and that national systems were operating at the highest level of readiness. It said missile threats detected yesterday morning were outside the UAE's borders and stressed there were no indications of concern while authorities continued to monitor developments around the clock.

— With AFP & WAM inputs

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